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The Amirs of Mīrzās

Return, O Huma, for without the parrot-down of thy lip. The crow will assuredly soon carry off my bones.

—Hasan Yaqub[*]

Khudai Birdi Tughchi Timur-Tash was an important Amir of Umar Shaikh. He was a descendant of Aq-Bugha Beg, who was the governor of Herat for Timur Beg. The story related to Khudai goes back to AD 1464 when Abu Sa‘id Mīrzā had captured Shahrukhiya by defeating Juki Mīrzā. He had awarded Ferghana to Umar, Babur’s father and Khudai Birdi Beg was made the head of Mīrzā’s Gate. Babur mentions that although Khudai was only twenty-five years of age, his management skills were unparalleled. Just a few years had passed, when Khudai had become an important part of Umar’s administration Ibrahim Begchik was on a plundering streak at Osh. But it had not been many years working for Umar, and Khudai thought of teaching a good lesson to Ibrahim. But fortune didn’t side with him this time. Khudai was beaten and killed in the face-off with Ibrahim.

Khudai had begun to take all decisions on his own as Sulṭān Ahmad Mīrzā was retiring in the summer pastures of Aq Qacghai, located in Aūrā-tīpā to the east of Samarkand. Sulṭān Abu Sa‘id Mīrzā was stationed at Baba Khaki, east of Herat. The news of the disaster was sent to the two Mīrzās through ‘Abdu’l-Wahhab Shaghawal. It took four days to carry the message for 500 miles on the road.

The Mīrzās were blessed with good Amirs mostly. Hafiz Muhammad Beg Duldai was another one after Khudai. He was the son of Sulṭān Malik Kashghari. After the tragic death of Khudai Beg, he was elevated and sent to control Umar Shaikh Mīrzā’s Gate. Unfortunately, he could not build the same rapport with the Andijān Begs, like Khudai. When Sulṭān Abu Sa‘id Mīrzā was on the verge of dying, he gave up the job of keeping Umar’s